

Episode 107: Once Upon a Time... (64) Incredible Population Density! The Staff Room for *Sailor Moon R* Movie

Now that production on the "pirate movie" has ended, I thought peaceful days had finally arrived... but thanks to the schedule getting severely delayed, my work on other projects I'm involved with is completely backed up. Last week I actually had to pull all-nighters for three days straight. Ah, maybe being captured by pirates was easier (wry laugh).

To add insult to injury, one of my home computer's HDDs died, and I lost work-related data (sob). Most of the data was backed up so it was okay, but the work data for a certain new project that I'd been preparing for a meeting was completely wiped out! This happened on the morning of the meeting day. I was so shocked I couldn't even speak. Naturally that day's meeting was postponed. I'm really sorry for the trouble! > All concerned parties

Everyone, back up your data early and often! (cry)

I somehow managed to recreate that tragic colour chart data from scratch, and had the rescheduled meeting the other day. Overall, I got the director's OK. This project starts broadcasting next year—I still can't write about it in detail, but please look forward to it as well.

Now then.

It might vary by production company and studio, but at Toei Animation (formerly Toei Doga), when a new project starts up, first a "staff room" gets set up.

The "staff room" is literally a room for staff. The director is at the centre, along with key animation directors, assistant directors, production managers and other main staff who are gathered in one room, and the project revolves around that room. Whether it's a TV series or theatrical work, the scale varies, but anyway, first there's the staff room.

Incidentally at Toei Animation (東映アニメーション), except for special cases, we colour designers and colour direction (色指定) staff don't have desks in the staff room. Since it's basically company employees who handle this work, we participate in projects from our own departmental desks within the company. Art staff work from within the company or outsourced production houses. This system remains the same today.

Ideally, all the main staff should be gathered in the same room, and in today's digitised environment that's relatively easy to do, but back when we used cel paints, you couldn't exactly bring paints and such along with you, so it became somewhat customary to work separately.

So, the staff room for *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R* movie was set up on the second floor of Oizumi Studio's so-called "new building."

Actually, this staff room had a slightly different atmosphere from other projects' staff rooms.

This room constantly housed Director Ikuhara, Assistant Director Igarashi Takuya, and production managers (the key animation directors worked at their own affiliated studios), plus one more person: Production Manager Higuchi.

"Production manager" is a uniquely Toei credit, a position that combines the roles of production producer and production desk. Higuchi, who was probably the most capable production manager at Toei Animation at the time, was in charge of "steering" the production of this project that was sure to become quite challenging.

Since this project had virtually no schedule, Higuchi employed a certain strategy to ensure the key animation would be completed. That strategy was to gather key animators in the staff room.

Writing it like that, you might think "isn't that normal?" Well, it's a typical measure production takes when pushing to finish key animation, but actually, the room we were using as the staff room this time was a bit—or rather extremely—small.

A concrete building with not particularly high ceilings, only one door, a sealed space of about ten-some tatami mats. Normally, just putting in desks for the director, assistant director, and two production staff would fill it up completely, but they kept bringing in as many animation desks as they could fit.

Higuchi placed one office desk right in the middle of the room so he could survey the entire staff room at once, then arranged animation desks around it one after another. Not just along the walls—they filled every gap, and when there were no more gaps, they'd angle desks to create gaps and fit in as many animation desks as possible. The animation desks were naturally all the smallest in-between animation size.

And then, the key animators who kept getting gathered.

Once you sat down, you were packed so tightly you couldn't easily get up. At peak capacity, there were probably about 10 people including the director. This was probably the highest population density in Oizumi Studio history, hands down.

And they'd keep people at their desks until they finished what they had on hand. Higuchi glared from the middle of the room (laugh), creating this somewhat tense atmosphere. And the door was always firmly shut (laugh).

Every time I had questions or consultations for the director and showed up at the staff room, the density of people made it somewhat difficult to talk (laugh). Key animation tends toward night work now and then. It was truly a fortress that never sleeps like this. During the production period, the lights in this room never went out.

Then, one by one, people would leave the staff room as they finished their assigned portions. The key animators dragging their tired bodies but cheerfully saying "Good work!" as they departed were quite memorable (laugh).

That was the tension under which the key animation progressed. And that key animation would next make its way to me.

(09.12.01)